

— EDITION 04

# PREGAME: MEXICO VS SOUTH AFRICA — THE OPENER

*16 years after Tshabalala, the rematch  
opens a World Cup.*

A 7-part breakdown

SWIPE ►►►

0101 / 07

# | MEXICO V SOUTH AFRICA.

Group A · Estadio Azteca, Mexico City ·  
Thursday June 11 · 3:00 PM ET. *The Azteca  
becomes the first stadium ever to open three  
World Cups — 1970, 1986, 2026.*

0202 / 07

# | WE HAVE BEEN HERE BEFORE.

11 June 2010, Soccer City. Tshabalala's screamer opened Africa's first World Cup. Rafael Márquez answered late. 1-1. *Sixteen years to the day, the fixture flips continents.*

0303 / 07

# | THE FORM GAP.

Mexico arrive unbeaten in eight in 2026 — Ghana 2-0, Australia 1-0, Serbia 5-1. South Africa's send-off: 0-0 with Nicaragua, 1-1 with Jamaica. *On paper, one-way. Openers don't read paper.*

0404 / 07

# | THE HOME TALISMAN.

Raúl Jiménez. 44 goals for Mexico — second only to Borgetti — and the man who equalised against the USA in the 2025 Gold Cup final. *El Lobo leads the line at the Azteca.*

0505 / 07

# | THE WALL IN HIS WAY.

Ronwen Williams — captain, goalkeeper, the man who saved four penalties in one AFCON shootout. *If Bafana Bafana survive the opening storm, it starts with him.*

0606 / 07

# | HOSTS DON'T LOSE OPENERS.

No host nation has ever lost a World Cup opening match. Mexico have opened at home twice before — and never lost at the Azteca in a World Cup. *Streaks exist to be tested.*

0707 / 07

# | YOUR CALL. SAVE THIS BRIEF.

Mexico's pace against the AFCON's best keeper, 16 years of history, and a stadium built for opening nights. *Drop your scoreline in the comments — we archive the verdicts at full time.*

— THE TAKEAWAY

# WHO TAKES THE **OPENER?**

Scoreline in the comments — and follow @fifa.archv for the daily tournament archive.